



Field Description Standard

One format for every column and measure, readable by people and by AI assistants.

A field description has three readers at once: the person hovering over a chart, the analyst building on the model, and the AI assistant deciding what a column means before it answers. One description has to serve all three. This is the format we apply to every column, measure, and calculated column in every model we build.

The format

Five sections, pipe separated. Human-readable and machine-parseable.

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[Plain-English summary]. | Source: [origin system]. | Logic: [calculation or derivation]. | Report alias: [display name in visuals, if different]. | Note: [how to use the field correctly].
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Section	Label	When to include	Rules
Summary	None	Always. Comes first.	Plain English, one or two sentences, no jargon. A reader who stops here should have the answer.
Source	Source:	When the origin system is not obvious	Name the system: the ERP, the ecommerce platform, the marketing tool, the manual table.
Logic	Logic:	Measures, calculated columns, any field where derivation matters	Explain the calculation in plain terms. Include the DAX where it adds clarity.
Report alias	Report alias:	Only when the visual shows a different name	State the alias and decode any abbreviation in it.
Note	Note:	Always. Comes last.	Behavioral guidance: how to use it, what to compare it against, what to avoid. Never a specific value, threshold, or date.

The rules

The format is easy. These are what keep it useful in three years.

The summary never has a label. Its position, always first, makes a label redundant. Writing "Summary:" is incorrect.

Not every section is required. A simple lookup column may need only a summary and a note. A complex measure may need all five. Include what adds context, nothing else.

The note never ages. No numbers, dates, thresholds, or benchmarks. Explain behavior, not values. A note that says "anything over 4% is a problem" is wrong the day the target moves.

Source and Logic are order-flexible. Either can come first, whichever reads more naturally for that field.

Every abbreviation is decoded where it appears. If the name or alias contains YTD, PP, ATC, or a system prefix, the description spells it out in Logic, Report alias, or Note.

Report alias only when the name differs. If the visual shows the field exactly as named in the model, omit the section.

Common abbreviations

Extend this table per client. The point is that the table exists.

Abbreviation	Meaning	Where it usually appears
YTD / MTD / QTD	Year, month, or quarter to date	Calendar flag columns
PP / PW / PD	Prior period, prior week, prior day. Same-length window shifted back.	Comparison measures
Flag_ (prefix)	Boolean Y/N filter column	Calendar and status columns
Offset	Integer distance from the current period. 0 = now, negative = past.	Calendar columns
Num (suffix)	Numeric sort key. For sorting only, never display.	Calendar columns
CF	Conditional formatting. Returns a hex color string, not a value.	Formatting measures
Delta pts	Change between two rates, in percentage points.	Rate comparison measures
OTIF	On time, in full	Fulfillment measures

Worked examples

Copied from production models, client specifics removed.

Column: Flag_YTD

Marks whether a date falls within the current year-to-date window. | Logic: 'Y' if date <= today AND year = current year, 'N' otherwise. | Note: Flag_ prefix = boolean Y/N filter column. YTD = Year To Date. Use as a visual filter set to 'Y' to restrict any chart to YTD automatically.

Column: CurMonthOffset

Integer distance between each date's month and the current month. | Logic: 0 = current month, -1 = prior month, -2 = two months ago. Calculated dynamically from today's date. | Note: Cur = Current, Offset = integer distance. Use in visual filters to show rolling month windows without hardcoding dates.

Measure: Click-to-Open Rate % (CTOR)

Of the recipients who opened the message, the share who clicked something. Measures content relevance independently of list size or deliverability. | Logic: $\text{DIVIDE}([\text{Total Clicks}], [\text{Total Opens}])$. Returns blank when opens are zero. | Note: CTOR = Click-To-Open Rate. More reliable than raw click rate for evaluating message quality. Compare within channel and audience type.

Measure: Disengagement Rate %

Combined signal of audience disengagement: the share of delivered messages that resulted in either an unsubscribe or a spam complaint. | Logic: $[\text{Unsubscribe Rate \%}] + [\text{Spam Complaint Rate \%}]$. | Note: Both actions represent active audience rejection. Compare within channel and audience type. Different segments have structurally different baselines.

Why this matters for AI

When Copilot or an assistant like Claude connects to a semantic model, the description is the first thing it reads about a field. A model with descriptions in this format answers a plain-English question from the metadata alone: what the number is, where it came from, how it was calculated, and how to compare it. A model without them answers from the column name, which is a guess dressed up as an answer.

Want the model documented for you?

Every Foundation Build ships with every field described in this format. If you already have a Power BI estate, the two-week AI Readiness Assessment scores how much of it is documented and what to fix first. Book a 30-minute discovery call: calendly.com/kettleriverbi/30min